



Luv, Pinky and Raju—the “Media Practitioners”



The recording studio in the media lab

Tripan Kumar alias Raju has been with the Media Lab for the past two-and-a-half years, and has enjoyed every moment of it. He is just 19, and is also studying for his class XII exam, from an open school.

Raju, though, is not the only computer-literate member of his family. “My sister is also attending a computer course,” he says. “I am here everyday from 10 am to 4 pm. I like fiddling with the computer and have also opened the CPU once,” says Raju.

Of late, Raju has been training on Windows Movie Maker with the help of Emma, a Swede helping the students at the Dakshinpuri media lab. “I have made a three-minute film using some of the photos Emma gave us,” he adds.

Kulwinder Kaur, or Pinky as she is known, is the co-ordinator

at the Dakshinpuri media lab. At 15, she is responsible for the day-to-day functioning of the lab. “It is my duty to designate work, see who is handling what equipment and keep track of the happenings,” explains Pinky. She also organises events for people within the *mohalla* that have eventually become projects for those at the media lab.

The Future

A common element amongst all associated with the Cybermohalla is selflessness. Everybody associated would like it to continue the way it is and for as long as possible.

As far as the program itself is concerned, Ankur now plans to extend its work to regions beyond Delhi. In August, a team of Mohalla Media Lab Practitioners (Lakhmi, Yashoda and Prabhat) visited Ahmedabad to help set up “Urja Ghar,” an Oxfam project where “locality media labs” would be set up for writing about the locality.

For two weeks in September, a team comprising representatives from Ankur and Sarai spent time with a group in England to participate in the processes of their lab and share some of the practices from Compughar labs in Delhi.

The interaction resulted in the setting up of an online journal where people can post diary entries about personal experiences and hobbies to create public awareness. This was to further spread the reach of the Cybermohalla.

Although the road seems long and arduous, the first steps have been taken. ☒

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In The Lab...

- ☐ Hardware in the media labs ranges from Celeron 566 MHz machines with 128 MB of RAM to Pentium IV 2.4 GHz machines with 256 MB of RAM. A media lab typically has a few machines networked with each other, and a dial-up connection to the Internet. Extra hardware includes inkjet printers, scanners and CD writers.
- ☐ Associated hardware that the labs use for their work includes digital cameras (Sony Powershots), Sony MiniDisc recorders, low-cost 35mm cameras, dictaphones, microphones and sound mixers.
- ☐ In addition to the Compughars, a special R&D lab has been set up that uses a Pentium IV 3 GHz server with 1GB of RAM to provide a thin client network using Linux Terminal Server Projects. Additionally, the R&D lab has a dedicated audio workstation.
- ☐ The labs run a special version of Gentoo GNU/Linux on their computer. They use KDE for their desktop environment and have the choice of working in Hindi or English. They can also choose to work in the GNOME, XFCE and icewm environments. The labs write text in Hindi using the UNICODE specification, and use a phonetic keymap called “BoINagri” developed by Sarai.

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